Lesson 12

Depression

"But as for me, I will always have hope;
I will praise you more and more."
(Psalm 71:14)

Depression: a pessimistic state of mind that affects thoughts, emotions, and behavior

Depression is one of the most common mental health problems in the entire world. People who are depressed feel sad, blue, or downhearted. They have lost their energy for life, and feel hopeless, helpless, worthless, and guilty. Fortunately, God's word is filled with inspiration for people who are feeling depressed.

Synopsis

Hopeless:

One of the triggers for depression is the false belief that your situation is hopeless. If you are a Christian, this is a lie that is contradicted throughout the Bible.

If you are feeling hopeless about life, try turning to God's word for guidance and direction. Everything written in the Bible was written to teach and encourage so that we might have hope.[1,2]

For everything that was written in the past was written to
teach us, so that through endurance and the
encouragement of the Scriptures
we might have hope.
(Romans 15:4)[1]

You are my refuge and my shield;
I have put my hope in your word.
(Psalm 119:114)[2]

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Throughout the Bible, we are reminded that God alone is the source of our hope.[3] In fact, the scriptures refer to God as the "God of hope."[4]

When Jesus Christ died on the cross and was raised from the dead, he became a living hope for all of us.[5] Because of Christ's sacrifice, we can now rest in the assurance that when we die, this is not the end of life, but only the beginning of eternity with Christ Jesus.[6]

If you are feeling downcast and gloomy about life, step back and put things in perspective.[7] Put your hope in God's promise of His glorious inheritance—eternal salvation and life ever after in heaven.[8] The Lord is good to those who place their hope in Him—to the one who seeks Him.[9] If you are feeling hopeless, turn back to God.

Find rest, O my soul, in God alone; my hope comes from him.
(Psalm 62:5)[3]

May the God of hope fill you with all joy and peace
as you trust in him, so that you may overflow with hope by
the power of the Holy Spirit.
(Romans 15:13)[4]

Praise be to the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ!
In his great mercy he has given us new birth into a living
hope through the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead.
(1 Peter 1:3)[5]

God has given us eternal life, and this life is in his Son.
(1 John 5:11)[6]

Why are you downcast, O my soul? Why so disturbed
within me? Put your hope in God, for I will yet praise him,
my Savior and my God.
(Psalm 43:5)[7]

I pray also that the eyes of your heart may be enlightened in
order that you may know the hope to which he has called you,
the riches of his glorious inheritance in the saints, and his
incomparably great power for us who believe.
(Ephesians 1:18-19)[8]

The LORD is good to those whose hope is in him,
to the one who seeks him.
(Lamentations 3:25)[9]

Regardless of your current situation, God's plans are for you to prosper and to have hope.[10]

If you put your hope in God, you will never be disappointed,[11] or put to shame.[12] Be patient in your afflictions and faithful in prayer.[12] Even if you are suffering, this experience can help develop character and ultimately lead to hope,[13] as you rest in God's unfailing love.[14]

As you turn to God for hope, be careful that you don't listen to the "false hopes" given by the world.[15] Watch what you say to yourself. Refuse to tell yourself your situation is hopeless,[16] and don't focus

"For I know the plans I have for you," declares the LORD,
"plans to prosper you and not to harm you,
plans to give you hope and a future."
(Jeremiah 29:11)[10]

Those who hope in me will not be disappointed.
(Isaiah 49:23)[11]

No one whose hope is in you will ever be put to shame.
(Psalm 25:3)[12]

But we also rejoice in our sufferings, because we know that suffering produces perseverance; perseverance, character; and character, hope.
(Romans 5:3)[13]

May your unfailing love rest upon us,
O LORD, even as we put our hope in you.
(Psalm 33:22)[14]

This is what the LORD Almighty says: "Do not listen to what the prophets are prophesying to you; they fill you with false hopes. They speak visions from their own minds, not from the mouth of the LORD.
(Jeremiah 23:16)[15]

You were wearied by all your ways, but you would not say, "It is hopeless." You found renewal of your strength, and so you did not faint.
(Isaiah 57:10)[16]

on your afflictions—focus on the Lord's compassion and love.[17] God knows your needs; you have not been forgotten.[18]

In the final analysis, only those who do not know God should feel hopeless.[19,20] For Christians, there is always hope.[21,22]

> *"But those who hope in the LORD will renew their strength. They will soar on wings like eagles; they will run and not grow weary, they will walk and not be faint."* (Isaiah 40:31)

Helpless:

If you are feeling helpless or powerless, turn to the Lord and His strength.[23] Remember that you have the Creator of the universe on your side.[24] He is the God who performs miracles and displays His power among the people.[25] Nothing is too hard for God.[26]

I remember my affliction and my wandering, the bitterness and the gall. I well remember them, and my soul is downcast within me. Yet this I call to mind and therefore I have hope:
Because of the LORD'S great love we are not consumed,
for his compassions never fail.
(Lamentations 3:19-22)[17]

But the needy will not always be forgotten,
nor the hope of the afflicted ever perish.
(Psalm 9:18)[18]

Such is the destiny of all who forget God;
so perishes the hope of the godless.
(Job 8:13)[19]

When a wicked man dies, his hope perishes;
all he expected from his power comes to nothing.
(Proverbs 11:7)[20]

But as for me, I will always have hope;
I will praise you more and more.
(Psalm 71:14)[21]

There is surely a future hope for you
and your hope will not be cut off.
(Proverbs 23:18)[22]

Be strong in the Lord and in His mighty power.[27] The Lord knows how to rescue godly men from trials.[28] If you are feeling helpless, try turning to God; the prayers of a righteous man are powerful and effective.[29] If we ask anything in God's name, He promises to provide.[30]

Worthless:

If you are feeling worthless, consider that you are made in God's image,[31,32] and that God loves you more than you can ever know or understand.[33,34]

It is God who arms me with strength
and makes my way perfect.
(Psalm 18:32)[23]

In his hand is the life of every creature and the
breath of all mankind.
(Job 12:10)[24]

You are the God who performs miracles;
you display your power among the peoples.
(Psalm 77:14)[25]

Ah, Sovereign LORD, you have made the heavens and
the earth by your great power and outstretched
arm. Nothing is too hard for you.
(Jeremiah 32:17)[26]

Finally, be strong in the Lord and in his mighty power.
(Ephesians 6:10)[27]

The Lord knows how to rescue godly men from trials.
(2 Peter 2:9)[28]

The prayer of a righteous man is powerful and effective.
(James 5:16)[29]

I tell you the truth, my Father will give you
whatever you ask in my name.
(John 16:23)[30]

So God created man in his own image, in the image of God he
created him; male and female he created them.
(Genesis 1:27)[31]

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God is our Heavenly Father,[35] and we are His offspring.[36] He has made us "a little lower than the heavenly beings," and He crowns us with glory and honor.[37] He counts the very hairs on our heads.[38] When we follow His commandments, Jesus Christ, who holds the keys to eternal life, even calls us His "friend."[39]

And just as we have borne the likeness of the earthly man,
so shall we bear the likeness of the man from heaven.
(1 Corinthians 15:49)[32]

How precious is your unfailing love!
(Psalm 36:7)[33]

I will sing of the LORD'S great love forever.
(Psalm 89:1)[34]

O LORD, you are our Father. We are the clay,
you are the potter.
(Isaiah 64:8)[35]

We are his offspring.
(Acts 17:28)[36]

You made him a little lower than the heavenly beings
and crowned him with glory and honor.
(Psalm 8:5)[37]

Indeed, the very hairs of your head are all numbered.
(Luke 12:17)[38]

You are my friends if you do what I command. I no longer
call you servants, because a servant does not know his
master's business. Instead, I have called you friends,
for everything that I learned from my Father
I have made known to you.
(John 15:14-15)[39]

Has not God chosen those who are poor in the eyes
of the world to be rich in faith and to inherit
the kingdom promised those who love him?
(James 2:5)[40]

You don't have to be rich or successful to be worthy in God's eyes,[40-42] and you don't have to be perfect.[43] Everyone sins[44] and everyone makes mistakes.[45] If you have broken God's commands, repent[46] and turn back to God.[47] He will receive you with open arms.[48]

Joyless:

People with depression have a difficult time experiencing joy and happiness. They have convinced themselves that there is nothing at all in this world in which to be happy. No matter what happens in their lives, they tend to look at the world "through dark colored glasses," and focus on the negative aspects of their experiences.

Wealth is worthless in the day of wrath
but righteousness delivers from death.
(Proverbs 11:4)[41]

Whoever trusts in his riches will fall,
but the righteous will thrive like a green leaf.
(Proverbs 11:28)[42]

There is not a righteous man on earth who does
what is right and never sins.
(Ecclesiastes 7:20)[43]

For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God.
(Romans 3:23)[44]

No one is good except God alone.
(Mark 10:18)[45]

Come back to your senses as you ought, and stop sinning.
(1 Corinthians 15:34)[46]

Let him turn to the LORD, and he will have mercy on him,
and to our God, for he will freely pardon.
(Isaiah 55:7)[47]

The eternal God is your refuge, and underneath
are the everlasting arms.
(Deuteronomy 33:27)[48]

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Christians who are joyless have lost perspective in life. They have let their own inadequacies or their own experiences blind them from the truth of the gospel and the source of all joy—our relationship with Jesus Christ our Lord and Savior, with God the Father who sent Him, and with the Holy Spirit who dwells within us.

As Christians, there are plenty of things about which to be joyful. If you are depressed and find it difficult experiencing joy, try meditating on God's incredible love for you.[49,50] Not only did God send His son to die for us, He sent the Holy Spirit to testify that we are His children.[51]

The God of the universe created us and gave us life.[52] We can rejoice in that fact and be glad for every day that God has given us on this planet.[53,54]

As the Father has loved me, so have I loved you.
Now remain in my love.
(John 15:9)[49]

May the Lord direct your hearts into God's love
and Christ's perseverance.
(2 Thessalonians 3:5)[50]

The Spirit himself testifies with our spirit that
we are God's children.
(Romans 8:16)[51]

For in him we live and move and have our being.
(Acts 17:28)[52]

I will praise you forever for what you have done.
(Psalm 52:9)[53]

This is the day the LORD has made;
let us rejoice and be glad in it.
(Psalm 118:24)[54]

Be joyful always, pray continuously, give thanks in all circumstances, for this is God's will for you in Christ Jesus.
(1 Thessalonians 5:16-18)[55]

Regardless of what has happened to us, we can still be joyful[55] and give thanks to the Lord for what He has done.[56] Sing joyfully to the Lord,[57] sing praise to Him; tell of all His wonderful acts.[58]

Energyless:

People who are depressed often feel weak and energyless. They have lost their zeal and enthusiasm for life. They find it difficult to "get going" and get things done.

If you are feeling weak and depleted in energy, turn to God for help. He gives strength to the weary, and increases the power of the weak.[59]

Draw on His strength, and seek His help.[60] If you are weary and burdened, He invites you to come to Him to find rest.[61] Pray for God to refresh your heart.[62]

Give thanks to the LORD, for he is good.
His love endures forever.
(Psalm 136:1)[56]

Sing joyfully to the LORD, you righteous;
it is fitting for the upright to praise him.
(Psalm 33:1)[57]

Sing to him, sing praise to him; tell of all his wonderful acts.
(Psalm 105:2)[58]

He gives strength to the weary and increases
the power of the weak.
(Isaiah 40:29)[59]

Look to the LORD and his strength; seek his face always.
(Psalm 105:4)[60]

Come to me, all you who are weary and burdened,
and I will give you rest.
(Matthew 11:28)[61]

Refresh my heart in Christ.
(Philemon 1:20)[62]

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Once you have been re-energized (or even if you are still feeling tired), one of the best things you can do to help yourself is to "get up" and "take action." If you are physically able, start taking walks and getting exercise; remember, your body is the temple of God, and you should take care of it.[63]

To the extent that you are physically able, go and help someone; helping others will serve to get your mind off your own problems. God does not want us to simply talk about our faith—he wants to see it in action.[64,65] Regardless of how tired you may feel, you can always find some way to reach out and help others. By so doing, you will be showing God's love[66] and helping yourself at the same time.[67]

Guilty:

People who are depressed often feel that they have committed some horrible act for which they can never be forgiven. As a result, their guilt is overwhelming. This is one of the biggest lies they can believe.

Apart from the special case of blasphemy, the Bible tells us that there is absolutely nothing that God will not forgive if we confess

Do you not know that your body is a temple of the Holy Spirit,
who is in you, whom you have received from God? You are
not your own; you were bought at a price.
Therefore honor God with your body.
(1 Corinthians 6:19-20)[63]

Dear children, let us not love with words or tongue
but with actions and in truth.
(1 John 3:18)[64]

Do not merely listen to the word, and so deceive yourselves.
Do what it says.
(James 1:22)[65]

Love one another deeply, from the heart.
(1 Peter 1:22)[66]

No one has ever seen God; but if we love one another,
God lives in us and his love is made complete in us.
(1 John 4:12)[67]

our sin and repent. Everyone who believes in Christ receives forgiveness of sins through His name.[68]

If you believe in Christ, there is no longer any condemnation for sin[69]—none whatsoever! This is precisely why Christ came to this earth to die for us, so that we could be reconciled with God. He laid down His life for us to take away our sins,[70] so that we could live forever with Him in heaven.

If you have sinned, there may certainly be unpleasant consequences in this world for what you have done.[71] A man reaps what he sows.[72] Fortunately, if you are a Christian, the consequences of your sin will not block your entrance to heaven.[73,74] After all, Christ came to this earth to save sinners, just like you and me.[75]

Everyone who believes in him
receives forgiveness through his name.
(Acts 10:43)[68]

Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus, because through Christ Jesus the law of the Spirit of life set me free from the law of sin and death.
(Romans 8:1-2)[69]

I am the good shepherd. The good shepherd lays down his life for the sheep.
(John 10:11)[70]

There will be trouble and distress for
every human being who does evil.
(Romans 2:9)[71]

Do not be deceived: God cannot be mocked.
A man reaps what he sows.
(Galatians 6:7)[72]

God demonstrates his own love for us in this:
While we were still sinners, Christ died for us.
(Romans 5:8)[73]

God was reconciling the world to himself in Christ,
not counting men's sins against them.
(2 Corinthians 5:19)[74]

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Try not to dwell on any wrongs you may have committed. Instead, confess your sins and then turn them over to God—knowing that they will never be counted against you.[76] If you have harmed someone, take time to confess your sin to him or her.[77]

Then, as far as possible, take any action you can that will lead to peace and restoration of the relationship.[78,79] If you are blocked from taking action, then pray for the person you have offended,[80] and ask for God's wisdom and guidance on how to proceed.

Finally, when you commit a sin you "grieve the Holy Spirit" who lives within you.[81] Therefore, it is only natural that you will experience temporary sorrow and guilt for what you have done. However, your guilt should be short-lived, as you move on to accept the

For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God,
and are justified freely by his grace through the
redemption that came by Christ Jesus.
(Romans 3:23-24)[75]

If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just and will forgive
us our sins and purify us from all unrighteousness.
(1 John 1:9)[76]

Confess your sins to each other and pray for each other
so that you may be healed.
(James 5:16)[77]

Let us therefore make every effort to what leads
to peace and to mutual edification.
(Romans 14:19)[78]

If it is possible, as far as it depends on you,
live at peace with everyone.
(Romans 12:18)[79]

And pray in the Spirit on all occasions
with all kinds of prayers and requests.
(Ephesians 6:18)[80]

And do not grieve the Holy Spirit of God,
with whom you were sealed for the day of redemption.
(Ephesians 4:30)[81]

awesome gift of forgiveness that was paid in full by Jesus Christ on the cross of Calvary.[82]

He himself bore our sins in his body on the tree,
so that we might die to sins and live for righteousness;
by his wounds we have been healed.
(1 Peter 2:24)[82]

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